



Tensions flare at Mullin’s hearing

Tussles with Paul, says he’ll restore reputation of embattled DHS

BY MARIA SACCHETTI AND MARIANA ALFARO

Sen. Markwayne Mullin defended his record at a fiery Senate confirmation hearing Wednesday over his nomination to lead the Department of Homeland Security, pledging to restore confidence in the embattled agency after a turbulent year that has led to widespread criticism.

Mullin (R-Oklahoma), who is President Donald Trump’s pick to replace Secretary Kristi L. Noem, portrayed himself during the three-hour hearing as a seasoned and blunt-spoken lawmaker and a family man prepared to combat terrorism, enforce immigration laws and work across party lines for public safety.

In a nod to Democrats who excoriated Noem’s leadership, Mullin vowed to take DHS in a different direction and to reduce tensions with local officials over immigration enforcement operations as the Trump administration pursues the president’s mass deportation agenda.

Mullin offered a measure of regret for statements he made accusing Alex Pretti, an American citizen protesting immigration raids, of being a “deranged individual” after federal immigration officers fatally shot him in Minneapolis in January. And Mullin pledged to require officers to obtain judicial warrants before entering private residences in most cases, one of the demands by Democrats who have withheld votes for a new DHS funding bill.

“My goal in six months is that we’re not in the lead story every single day,” Mullin told the Senate Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs Committee. “My goal is for people to understand we’re out there, we’re protecting them, and we’re working with them. My goal is to make every one of you guys proud.”

But Mullin, 48, faced tough questioning not just from the seven Democrats on the 15-member committee but also from Chairman Rand Paul (R-Kentucky), who opened the hearing with a withering critique based on a long-standing feud between

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KEVIN LAMARQUE/REUTERS

Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard departed from her prepared remarks about an assessment of Iran’s nuclear capability.



ALEX KENT/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Sen. Markwayne Mullin (R-Oklahoma) said he would aim to take the Department of Homeland Security in a less turbulent direction.

Israel increasingly pursues lethal strikes on Iranian leaders

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE, VICTORIA CRAW, LIOR SOROKA AND ABBIE CHEESEMAN

Israel has stepped up assassinations of top Iranian officials in recent days, in what the Israel Defense Forces said was a push to undermine command and control in Iran after more than two

weeks of devastating airstrikes that have wiped out military infrastructure but not dislodged the regime.

But as Iran continues to escalate retaliatory strikes against its Persian Gulf neighbors, it is unclear what impact the targeting of senior leadership is having on Iran’s war effort. After an Israeli strike on Iran’s South Pars gas

field Wednesday, Iran struck back at Persian Gulf energy facilities, roiling global energy markets.

“An eye for an eye equation is in effect, and a new level of confrontation has begun,” said Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Ghalibaf, following the attack on South Pars, one of the world’s largest gas fields. Ghalibaf accused Israel of attacking

infrastructure to conceal battlefield defeats in an X post.

The attack on South Pars is “dangerous & irresponsible,” said Qatar’s Foreign Ministry spokesman, Majed al-Ansari, in a post

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Colorado, Maine put trans athletes’ rights on the ballot

Opposition groups made push to get issues before voters in political debate

BY DANIEL WU

Maine and Colorado this week approved ballot initiatives by advocacy groups seeking to ban transgender student-athletes from playing on girls’ sports teams, putting a debate that has become an enduring political flash point up for direct vote in blue states where leaders have resisted such policies.

The states are the latest to take up the issue this election year. Voters in Washington state will also vote on trans athletes in November, and similar measures

have been proposed in Arizona, Nevada and Nebraska.

The groups pushing the initiatives, which would bar transgender student-athletes from participating in sports teams of their gender identity, have called them citizen-led efforts to bypass state legislatures. Critics said the proposed bans are discriminatory.

Leyland Streiff, with the advocacy group Protect Girls Sports in Maine, said in an interview that a majority vote would be “the most democratic way possible” to decide on the issue and that the petition sidesteps “elected officials that are clearly out of touch right now with what the rest of the state actually wants.”

“This is a common-sense issue, and we believe that the group that we have gathered are people who sit across all of those different

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A Senate hopeful’s populist bet to win over Mich. voters

BY OLIVIA GEORGE



EVAN COBB/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Grand Rapids resident Kareem Scales, left, speaks with U.S. Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed.

GENESEE COUNTY, MICH. — The sky had long been dark when the white minivan pulled into the packed parking lot of the mosque on the outskirts of Flint for Abdul El-Sayed’s last campaign stop of the day. He walked inside and removed his shoes near the wall covered in posters reading “Free Palestine,” drawn by children and scrawled with heart doodles.

“We are in the month of Ramadan,” El-Sayed said that night in late February, asking the worshippers kneeling on the carpet to consider their blessings and responsibilities. “None of us today, when we woke up, had to think about whether or not our home was going to be bombed.”

He added: “Every dollar that is spent dropping a bomb on somebody else is a dollar that is not spent providing good health care or good schools.”

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